LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

How Long Does It Really Take to Build a Habit?

The truth about the 21-day myth, what really happens when you miss a day, and natural English for talking about your habits – plus Jack's orange running shoes.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · After you listen 💬
Solve the word search, plan your tiny habit and share it in the comments!

0 Warm-up: My habit confession

fun · no points

Be honest! Tick every habit you started with lots of energy… and then stopped. 😅

- ☐ 👟 running
- ☐ 📓 a journal
- ☐ 📱 an app
- ☐ 🏋 the gym
- ☐ 📚 reading
- ☐ 🎸 music

When did you stop?

(a) after 1 week (b) after 2–3 weeks (c) after one missed day

🎧 **Many people stop at the same time – find out why at ⏱ 5:19**

Jack: "I bought bright orange running shoes in April. Now they're very expensive slippers. Great for making tea!" ☕



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. What's one good habit you have now? How did it start?

2. How many days do you think it takes to build a habit?

3. What do you do every day on "autopilot"?

4. What do you do when you miss a day of studying?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Check in the Word Tour at ⏱️ 13:41

- ☐ **1.** automatic
- ☐ **2.** on autopilot
- ☐ **3.** consistent
- ☐ **4.** context
- ☐ **5.** willpower
- ☐ **6.** a myth
- ☐ **7.** a streak
- ☐ **8.** to fall behind
- ☐ **9.** it slipped my mind
- ☐ **10.** to get back on track

a) an idea many people believe, but it isn't true
b) I forgot about it
c) doing things without really paying attention
d) the ability to control yourself and do something difficult
e) done without thinking, like brushing your teeth
f) to return to your plan after a difficult time
g) the situation, place or time around something
h) a period of doing something every day without missing
i) doing something regularly, in the same way
j) to do less than you planned, so you're not where you wanted to be



Pronunciation corner 🔊 Find the strong part! con-**SIS**-tent · au-to-**MA**-tic · **AU**-to-pi-lot · **WILL**-pow-er · **HA**-bit. Say it out loud: *"Being consistent is more important than willpower."*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) If you work hard, any new habit becomes automatic in exactly 21 days.
- (b) Good habits depend mostly on strong willpower, so you must never miss a day.
- (c) A new habit often takes two months or more – and one missed day doesn't ruin it.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

slippers · journal · bridge · pillow · guitar · shortcut · dog walker · chocolate

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. If something is "automatic", you do it…

(a) very slowly
(b) without thinking
(c) with a friend

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

2. "I've got into the habit _____ reading before bed."

(a) to
(b) for
(c) of

🧠 Grammar you know

3. You forgot your English lesson. The most natural sentence is…

(a) "It slipped my mind."
(b) "My mind slipped it."
(c) "It went out from my head."

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

4. A "myth" is an idea that is…

(a) popular, but not true
(b) new and scientific
(c) difficult to understand

🧠 Look at Exercise 1

5. To start a new habit, it's usually best to…

(a) wait for next Monday
(b) start with something big
(c) start with something tiny

🧠 Common sense

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. What was Maxwell Maltz's job?

(a) a sports coach
(b) a plastic surgeon
(c) a teacher

🎧 ⏱️ 2:30

7. Which habits became automatic faster?

(a) simple ones, like drinking water with lunch
(b) difficult ones, like exercise
(c) all habits took the same time

🎧 ⏱️ 3:45

8. Weeks two and three are hard because…

(a) people get ill
(b) the habit becomes boring forever
(c) the excitement has gone, but the habit isn't automatic yet

🎧 ⏱️ 5:19

9. Wendy Wood says habits are mostly about…

(a) context
(b) willpower
(c) money

🎧 ⏱️ 8:09

10. Where did Jack put his running shoes the night before his run?

(a) under his bed
(b) by the front door
(c) in the kitchen

🎧 ⏱️ 19:36

🧩 **Fun fact:** The "21 days" idea came from a surgeon's notes about patients **getting used to a new face** – not about habits at all!

4 Number detective 🔍

new! listening for numbers · 8 points

Numbers go fast in English! Listen and write the missing number in each box.



1. In April, Jack went running only ___ times. ⏱ 0:05

2. Maltz wrote it took a minimum of about ___ days. ⏱ 2:30

3. The UCL study followed ___ people. ⏱ 3:45

4. They followed them for ___ weeks. ⏱ 3:45

5. On average, a new habit took ___ days. ⏱ 3:45

6. For the fastest people, it took ___ days. ⏱ 3:45

7. For others, it took up to ___ days! ⏱ 3:45

8. About ___ % of what we do every day is repeated in the same situation. ⏱ 8:09



Did you know? In British English, we say **"and"** in big numbers: 254 = *two hundred **and** fifty-four*. Watch the stress, too: thir**TEEN** (13) vs **THIR**ty (30). Say your answers out loud!

5 True or false?

listening · 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱ times help you find the answer.

1	Lucy wrote in her journal for 21 days and then stopped.	T	F	⏱ 0:05
2	Maltz was writing about building new habits.	T	F	⏱ 2:30
3	In the study, missing one day didn't really affect the habit.	T	F	⏱ 5:19
4	Wendy Wood says people with amazing self-control are just stronger than others.	T	F	⏱ 8:09
5	Jack suggests studying English for one hour a day at the start.	T	F	⏱ 9:14
6	Lucy's rule is: "I can miss one day, but I won't miss two days in a row."	T	F	⏱ 9:14



The middle of the bridge: in weeks two and three, you can't see the start anymore – and you can't see the end yet. If it still feels difficult, that's **normal**. Keep walking!

📏 How long does a habit really take? (no points – check your answers to Exercise 4 here after you listen!)



Write the numbers from Exercise 4 on the line: **fastest · the myth · average · slowest**. Where would **your** English habit be? Draw a ⭐!

6 "How's the Spanish going?" listening 10 points



Listen to the two friends at ⏱ 11:43. Write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer A and B. The phrase breakdown at ⏱ 12:54 can help.



LUCY
So, how's the Spanish going? You were so excited about it in January.

JACK
Don't ask. I kept it 1 _____ for about three weeks, and then I fell 2 _____. And once I'd missed a few days, I just gave up.





LUCY
Oh, that's such a 3 _____. You were doing so well.

JACK
I know. I was really getting 4 _____ it. But then work got busy, and it just slipped my 5 _____.





LUCY
Happens to everyone. Why don't you start again, but smaller? Like ten minutes a day.

JACK
Ten minutes? That doesn't sound like enough.





LUCY
It's better than 6 _____ minutes. And you could do it on the bus. You take the bus every day anyway.

JACK
That's actually a good idea. I could make it part of my 7 _____.





LUCY
Exactly. And if you miss a day, don't beat yourself up about it. Just carry on the next day.

JACK
Okay. I'll give it another 8 _____. Ten minutes, on the bus, starting Monday.





LUCY
Why not tomorrow?

JACK
Fine. Tomorrow. 😅



A. Which phrase means **"don't criticise yourself too much"**? Copy it:

B. Lucy connects the new habit to an **old** one. Which old habit?

🎭 **Shadow it!** Pause after each line and copy Jack's rhythm out loud (Lucy's idea at ⏱ 19:03).

7 Habit words that go together

collocations + idioms · 6 points



Complete each sentence with a word from the box. Change the form if you need to. 🎧 Help at ⏱️ 16:15

break · **creature** · **die** · **get into** · **kick** · **make**

1. I'm trying to _____ the habit of checking my phone in bed.
2. I've _____ the habit of reading before bed. I love it!
3. I want to _____ this a habit, so I'll do it every morning.
4. My dad has had the same breakfast for thirty years. He's a real _____ of habit.
5. I still check my work emails on holiday. Old habits _____ hard!
6. She drank five coffees a day, but last year she finally _____ the habit. (= stopped a bad habit)

8 Used to · be used to · get used to

new! grammar · 4 points

Maltz's patients needed time to **get used to** their new face. Three similar phrases – three different meanings!

used to + verb
a past habit that has **stopped**
"I used to run every day."

be used to + -ing / noun
it's **normal** for you now
"I'm used to getting up early."

get used to + -ing / noun
it's **becoming** normal
"You'll get used to it!"

1. When Lucy started, she _____ write a whole page. Now she writes three lines.
2. After an operation, the patients needed time to _____ their new face.
3. I'm a morning person, so I _____ waking up early. It's easy for me.
4. Running is hard at first, but your body will _____ it.



Jack's tip: After **be used to** and **get used to**, the verb needs **-ing**: *"I'm used to wak**ing** up early"* – not *"I'm used to wake up"*. It's one of the most common learner mistakes!

Now talk about you! (no points) Finish the sentences – then say them out loud.

When I was a child, I **used to** _____.

Now I'**m used to** _____.

I'm still **getting used to** _____.

9 Good setup or bad setup?

think · 6 points



Wendy Wood says habits depend on **context**, not willpower. Tick ✓ GOOD if the setup helps a good habit, or ✕ BAD if it helps a bad habit. 🎧 Check at ⏱️ 8:09

👟🚪

1. Your running shoes are by the front door.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

📱🛏️

2. Your phone is next to your bed.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

📖🛏️

3. Your English book is on your pillow.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

🍪💻

4. A big box of biscuits is on your desk.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

☕🎧

5. You play a podcast every time you make coffee.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

🔔📚

6. Notifications are on while you study.

☐ ✓ GOOD ☐ ✕ BAD

💡 **Make good habits easy** (put them where you can see them) and **bad habits hard** (put them away). It's less about being strong – and more about being clever!

10 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 17:00

😐 1. "I want to do this every day as a habit." 😊 _____

😐 2. "I forgot to study, it went out of my head." 😊 _____

😐 3. "I stopped, I will start again." 😊 _____

😐 4. "Don't be angry with yourself so much." 😊 _____

😐 5. "I didn't do it many days, I am behind now." 😊 _____



Lucy's tip – sound modern: When you do something every day without missing, say **"I'm on a streak!"** 🔥 *"Four days of journaling – I'm on a streak!"*

💭 Change the story

be kind · no points

"The problem is never the missed day. It's the **story we tell ourselves** about it." Rewrite each thought in a kinder way.

😣 *"I missed one day. That's it, I've failed."*

😊 **"I missed one day. That's normal – I'll start again tomorrow."**

😣 *"I'll start again next Monday."*

😊 _____

😣 *"Ten minutes is useless."*

😊 _____

11 Clue word search + secret message

puzzle · 12 points



Step 1: Complete each clue – the first letter and the number of letters are given (1 point each). **Step 2:** Find the 12 words in the grid. They go → ↓ ↘ or ↗ and never cross each other.

1 Brushing your teeth is **a**_____ – you do it without thinking.
2 "I drove home on **a**_____. I don't remember the journey!"
3 Being **c**_____ is more important than studying for hours.
4 Habits depend on **c**_____: the place, the time, what you did before.
5 Habits are not mostly about **w**_____.
6 "21 days" is a **m**_____ – popular, but not true.
7 Four days in a row – Lucy's on a **s**_____!
8 Listen, then do the worksheet: make it part of your **r**_____.
9 Lucy writes three lines in her **j**_____ every morning.
10 Weeks two and three are like the middle of a **b**_____.
11 People walk across the grass to take a **s**_____.
12 Jack wore his running shoes as **s**_____ in the kitchen.

S	L	I	P	P	E	R	S	T	R	T
A	J	O	U	R	N	A	L	E	N	S
U	B	R	I	D	G	E	W	E	A	H
T	H	E	G	R	A	O	T	C	U	O
O	S	S	D	O	P	S	K	O	T	R
P	E	S	N	L	I	A	T	N	O	T
I	G	R	L	S	E	O	W	T	M	C
L	B	I	N	R	M	A	C	E	A	U
O	W	O	T	K	O	Y	V	X	T	T
T	C	S	E	R	N	I	T	T	I	G
R	O	U	T	I	N	E	H	H	C	T

🤫 **Step 3 – the secret message** (no points) Cross out the 12 words. Then write the letters that are left, row by row, from left to right. They make Lucy's favourite sentence from the episode!

_____ _____ _____ _____ _____

_____

What does it mean? Write it in your own words: _____

12 The story of the orange shoes

listening · 6 points



Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes. ⏱️ 0:05 and 19:36

☐ 🌙 One night, Jack put the shoes by the front door.

☐ 🛍️ In April, Jack bought bright orange running shoes.

☐ 🐕 A dog walker overtook him!

☐ 🩴 For months, he wore them as slippers in the kitchen.

☐ 🌅 In the morning, he saw them first and ran for ten minutes.

☐ 🏃 He went running only three times.



13 Your turn: your habit story

writing · 10 points

Use today's phrases. 2 points for each good sentence.

A. A habit I started and stopped

① I started… ② I kept it up for… but then… *(fell behind / slipped my mind)* ③ Next time, I'm going to…

B. Habit stacking 🔗

Connect a **new** English habit to an **old** one. Write two sentences.

After I _____, I will _____.

After I _____, I will _____.

e.g. After I make my coffee, I will listen to an English podcast.

🌱 Make your own path

your 14-day mission

Every step makes the path across the park a little clearer. Colour a stone each day you do your tiny habit.

My tiny English habit: After I _____, I will _____.

1 2 3 4 5 6 7

8 9 10 11 12 13 14 🎉

Missed a day? That's normal – the grass doesn't grow back overnight! Just follow Lucy's rule: **never miss two days in a row.** Most habits need about two months – so keep going! 💪

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🚀 START
I want to make this a habit.
I'm getting into the habit of…

😅 OOPS
It completely slipped my mind.
I've fallen behind.

🔁 AGAIN
I'll give it another go.
I'm getting back on track.

💜 BE KIND
Don't beat yourself up.
Go easy on yourself.

Can you do it now?

I can…	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain why "21 days" is a myth.	😟	🙂	😄
talk about a habit I started and stopped.	😟	🙂	😄
use used to, be used to and get used to correctly.	😟	🙂	😄
make a plan: "After I…, I will…"	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! Finish this sentence in the comments: **"After I…, I will…"** And do you have your own "orange running shoes" – something you bought for a habit that never happened? 👟💜

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Your own answers – most people stop after 2–3 weeks or one missed day. · Predict: **guitar** 🎸 isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 e · 2 c · 3 i · 4 g · 5 d · 6 a · 7 h · 8 j · 9 b · 10 f
Big idea: c (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 b · 2 c · 3 a · 4 a · 5 c · 6 b · 7 a · 8 c · 9 a · 10 b

4 · Number detective

1 three (3) · 2 21 · 3 96 · 4 12 · 5 66 · 6 18 · 7 254 · 8 43

5 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (getting used to a new face) · 3 T · 4 F (they organise their lives so good things are easy) · 5 F (five words or ten minutes) · 6 T

6 · "How's the Spanish going?"

1 up · 2 behind · 3 shame · 4 into · 5 mind · 6 zero · 7 routine · 8 go · A "Don't beat yourself up about it." · B taking the bus every day

7 · Habit words that go together

1 break · 2 got into · 3 make · 4 creature · 5 die · 6 kicked

8 · Used to · be used to · get used to

1 used to · 2 get used to · 3 am used to ('m used to) · 4 get used to

9 · Good setup or bad setup?

✔GOOD: 1, 3, 5 · ✖BAD: 2, 4, 6

10 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 I want to make this a habit. · 2 It completely slipped my mind. · 3 I'm going to give it another go. / I'm getting back on track. · 4 Don't beat yourself up about it. / Go easy on yourself. · 5 I've fallen behind. / I've got a bit behind.

11 · Word search (1 point per word)

1 automatic · 2 autopilot · 3 consistent · 4 context · 5 willpower · 6 myth · 7 streak · 8 routine · 9 journal · 10 bridge · 11 shortcut · 12 slippers
Secret: The grass doesn't grow back overnight. (= one missed day doesn't erase your progress)



12 · The orange shoes · 13 · Your habit story

1 🛍️ bought · 2 🏃 three times · 3 🩴 slippers · 4 🌙 by the door · 5 🌅 ten minutes · 6 🐕 dog walker
13: your own answers! e.g. "I kept it up for two weeks, but then it slipped my mind." · "After I brush my teeth, I will learn five words." 2 points per good sentence.

90–100 🏆	70–89 🔥	50–69 🛤️	0–49 🌉
Creature of (good) habit!	On a streak	Back on track	Middle of the bridge – keep going!

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